The Jungle Book

A simplified retelling

Original story by Rudyard Kipling

The same journey. Clearer, shorter English.

Abridged and retold for Speak Boldly Intermediate reading practice

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1. Mowgli’s brothers

One night, a small human child entered a wolf family’s cave. Shere Khan, the tiger, wanted him. Mother Wolf refused to surrender the child and called him Mowgli.

At the pack’s meeting, the wolves had to decide whether he could stay. Baloo the bear spoke for him. Bagheera the panther offered a freshly killed bull to support his acceptance. Akela, the leader, allowed Mowgli to grow up among the wolves.

Baloo taught him the jungle’s rules. Bagheera taught him to watch carefully and understand danger. Shere Khan, however, encouraged younger wolves to resent the human child.

When Akela grew old, his enemies tried to remove him and give Mowgli to the tiger. Bagheera warned Mowgli to obtain fire, which animals feared. Mowgli brought it to the meeting and drove Shere Khan back. He protected Akela, but realised that some wolves would never accept him.

He cried for the first time in a way his animal family could not fully share. Then he left to find people. He had

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grown up in the jungle, but being human had become something he could no longer ignore.

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2. Kaa’s hunting

Earlier in Mowgli’s childhood, Baloo had warned him about the Bandar-log, the monkeys. They had no steady leader or reliable rules. Mowgli was tempted by their attention and promises of admiration.

The monkeys carried him away to an abandoned city. At first, the journey was exciting. Soon he discovered that they could not keep their promises or agree on what to do with him.

As he was taken through the trees, Mowgli called to Chil the kite using a phrase Baloo had taught him. Chil carried the news to his friends.

Baloo and Bagheera asked Kaa, the great python, to help. Kaa was one of the few creatures the monkeys truly feared. At the ruined city, the rescuers fought through a crowd of monkeys. Bagheera was nearly overwhelmed until he reached water.

Kaa broke into the enclosure where Mowgli was trapped and helped release him. Afterwards, Mowgli thanked his rescuers and faced the consequences of ignoring the warning. Being admired by the monkeys had not made

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him safe in their care.

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3. Tiger! Tiger!

After leaving the wolf pack, Mowgli reached a village. A woman named Messua believed he might be her long-lost child and welcomed him. He learned to wear clothes, speak with people and herd buffaloes.

Village customs confused him. He could understand the animals, but human rules often seemed less sensible than the jungle law. A hunter named Buldeo disliked being questioned by the boy.

Mowgli’s wolf brother brought news: Shere Khan was nearby and planned to kill him. With help from the wolves, Mowgli divided the buffalo herd and drove the animals through a ravine from opposite directions. Shere Khan was trapped and trampled.

When Buldeo saw Mowgli with the wolves, he spread fear in the village. The people drove Mowgli away, despite Messua’s attempts to protect him.

Mowgli returned to the jungle with the tiger’s skin. He had defeated Shere Khan, but he had not found a simple answer to where he belonged. With four wolf brothers beside him, he continued hunting beyond the pack’s

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authority.

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4. The White Seal

Far from the jungle, a white seal named Kotick grew up among great groups of seals in the North Pacific. As he became older, he discovered a danger the playful young animals did not understand.

People drove seals away from the beach and killed them for their skins. Kotick escaped and began searching for a place where his kind could live without being hunted.

The search took years. Other sea creatures could offer information, but no easy answer. Eventually, Kotick followed slow-moving sea cows through an underwater passage. Beyond it, he found an isolated beach with safe space for the seals.

Discovering it was not enough. The other seals were used to returning to the same place and did not want to follow a young animal’s claim. Kotick had to prove his strength and persistence before they would listen.

At last, he led others to the hidden shore. His unusual colour had made him noticeable, but his achievement came from continuing a search that comfortable animals saw no reason to begin.

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5. Rikki-Tikki-Tavi

A flood carried a young mongoose into an English family’s garden in India. They rescued him, and he became especially close to their son, Teddy. His name was Rikki-Tikki-Tavi.

The garden held dangerous neighbours: the cobras Nag and Nagaina. They feared the mongoose because he could kill snakes. If the humans left, the cobras hoped to control the garden again.

Rikki killed a smaller snake that threatened Teddy. Later, he overheard the cobras planning an attack inside the house. He fought Nag in the bathroom, and the father’s gun helped end the danger.

Nagaina remained. With information from the birds, Rikki found and destroyed most of her eggs. He kept the last one to distract her when she threatened the family at breakfast.

She seized it and fled into her underground hole. Rikki followed, although fighting in her own darkness was extremely dangerous. The creatures outside thought he had died. Finally, he emerged alive. The family and the

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garden were safe, and his courage had made a lasting place for him there.

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6. Toomai of the elephants

Little Toomai helped his father care for an elephant named Kala Nag. He was fascinated by the work of catching and training elephants and wanted to take part in the most difficult tasks.

The experienced elephant hunter Petersen Sahib noticed him. Jokingly, he said that Toomai could become a proper elephant catcher when he had seen the elephants dance. Nobody expected him to do such a thing.

One night, Kala Nag moved away from camp with Toomai on his back. Other elephants joined them. They travelled to a hidden place in the forest, where the animals stamped and moved together for hours, clearing the ground beneath them.

Toomai watched from Kala Nag’s back until morning. When they returned, he was exhausted but determined to tell what he had seen.

Trackers examined the place and confirmed his account. The adults celebrated him, and he received a new name, Toomai of the Elephants. The small helper had witnessed

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something that the experienced men knew mainly through stories.

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7. Her Majesty’s servants

At a military camp in the rain, a narrator listened to the transport animals talking after a frightened camel disturbed their rest. Mules, horses, bullocks, camels and an elephant described their work and their fears.

Each knew a different part of the same operation. A horse understood carrying a rider into danger. Mules knew steep paths and heavy loads. Bullocks pulled guns. The elephant’s great strength did not make him fearless; his ability to imagine danger could trouble him deeply.

The animals argued about whose service mattered most. Gradually, their discussion revealed how much depended on cooperation and on trusting signals from those directing them.

The following day, a grand parade displayed the organised force of the camp. To an observer, its order looked impressive. The conversation in the rain had shown the nervous, practical effort beneath that appearance.

Across these stories, strength took many forms: physical force, patient searching, quick action and the willingness

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to learn a rule before depending on it. Belonging, too, was rarely as simple as being born in the right place.

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Words to keep

Pack — a group of wolves living and hunting together. Akela led the pack.

Ravine — a deep, narrow valley. Mowgli trapped the tiger in a ravine.

Persistence — continuing despite difficulty or delay. Kotick’s persistence led him to a safer shore.

Mongoose — a small animal known for fighting snakes. Rikki was a mongoose.

Witness — to see an event happen. Toomai witnessed the elephants’ gathering.

Cooperation — working together towards a shared result. The camp depended on cooperation.

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A question to carry with you

Which character best shows that being strong is different from being unafraid? Explain your choice using one event.

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